Challenge Stigma / Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #39

Faith, God, and Big Questions After Trauma

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Field notes for when trauma breaks your faith and spirituality fractures.

By Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW
Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. What Is Happening

Your faith said you'd be protected. Your prayers weren't answered. Something horrible happened that contradicts everything you believed about a good God or a benevolent universe. Now you're wrestling with theodicy: how can God be good and all-powerful AND allow this suffering? Some people lose faith entirely. Some people have faith but it's been radically reshaped. Some people are in the middle—believing in something but not the framework they were taught. Your spiritual understanding is fractured, and you don't know how to rebuild it.

Common signs

- Loss of faith: You no longer believe in God or your faith tradition.
- Spiritual crisis: Faith feels impossible but so does abandoning it.
- Anger at God or the divine: You feel betrayed by the spiritual framework you trusted.
- Existential disorientation: The meaning-making system that structured your life no longer works.
- Isolation from faith community: You've withdrawn from church/temple/mosque because existing there feels like lying.
- Conflict with believers: People in your faith are saying 'God has a plan' and you want to scream.
- Loss of spiritual practices: Prayer, meditation, ritual—they felt healing before and now they feel hollow.
- Search for new meaning: You're looking for understanding outside traditional faith frameworks.

> **This is not failure of faith or weakness:**
> Trauma breaks spiritual frameworks that made sense before. Rebuilding meaning after that takes real work.

2. Why It Escalates

Faith creates a framework for meaning: 'God is good, I'm protected, suffering has redemptive purpose.' Trauma says 'You're not protected, and there's no redemptive meaning here.' These can't both be true in the form you learned them. Your nervous system and your beliefs are in conflict. If you were taught 'pray and you'll be safe,' and you prayed and weren't safe, now prayer feels like evidence that faith doesn't protect. Add hypervigilance (you're critical of faith platitudes now) and moral injury (if teaching instructed you to resign yourself to suffering without accountability), and you get spiritual fracture.

Common amplifiers

- Theodicy crisis spiraling: 'Why did God allow this?' has no satisfying answer, so faith crumbles.
- Community isolation deepening: Believers offer platitudes, you withdraw, you feel more alone.
- Spiritual bypassing from others: 'It's part of God's plan' OR 'You should forgive' makes you feel unheard.
- Meaning loss cascading: If spiritual meaning is gone, other meaning systems feel shaky too.
- Guilt about losing faith: You were 'supposed to' have unshakeable faith, so losing it feels like personal failure.
- Loss of spiritual practices: Prayer/meditation/ritual were coping tools. Losing them eliminates a regulation strategy.
- Identity fracture: If spiritual identity was core, losing faith is losing yourself.

> *Why this works: reducing total load and increasing predictability lowers baseline arousal and improves regulation.*

3. What To Do This Week

Spiritual healing after trauma is not about returning to old faith. It's about reconstructing meaning in a way that honors both the trauma AND what you still believe (if anything).

1. Acknowledge the spiritual wound: Faith frameworks didn't protect you. Grieve that and don't try to fix it immediately.
2. Question carefully: Sit with 'Why did this happen?' without rushing to an answer. Some questions don't have satisfying answers.
3. Separate faith teaching from lived experience: What you were taught might not match reality. Both can be true.

4. Explore what fractured: Is it specific doctrine, the institution, your belief in divine protection, all of it? Get specific.
5. Notice what spiritual practices still help: If any prayer/meditation/ritual brings even small relief, those can stay.
6. Seek faith-aligned support if you need it: Chaplains, spiritual directors, or therapists trained in religious trauma are different from regular clergy.
7. Rebuild beliefs deliberately: Slow reconstruction beats forced belief. 'I don't know if God is good, but I believe X' is valid.
8. Create new spiritual practices: If old ones are broken, build new meaning-making that fits your current understanding.
9. Accept hybrid belief: You can be a Christian who doesn't believe certain doctrines. You can be 'spiritual but not religious.' You can be agnostic and still believe in something.
10. Reconnect with faith community IF it serves you: Some communities can hold your doubt. Some can't. Choose accordingly.

> Field rule: set the bar low enough to do it even on your worst day.

4. For Partners and Team

Stress communication should be clear, brief, and repeatable. Predictable routines protect relationships.

- Use concrete language: 'My faith was broken by trauma. I'm rebuilding my understanding slowly.'
- Name what you need: 'I need you to stop explaining God's plan. I need permission to doubt and to grieve.'
- Invite them in authentically: 'I'm struggling spiritually. I need support that honors my doubt, not platitudes.'
- Protect your space: 'I need to step back from faith community right now while I figure this out. It's not rejection of the community, it's self-protection.'

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5. When To Get More Help

Self-guided tools are a start. Escalate care when symptoms persist, spread, or begin harming safety and function.

- Spiritual crisis is accompanying suicidal ideation or loss of meaning to live.

- You've completely abandoned faith and feel untethered (or it's been so long you can't rebuild).
- You're in conflict with your faith community and feel isolated.
- You can't access spiritual practices that once helped and you're grieving the loss.
- Faith-informed trauma therapy, spiritual direction, or chaplain support can help rebuild meaning after spiritual fracture.

6. 7-Day Field Drill

Use the worksheet every day for one week. Track trigger, body signal, and reset action. Keep what works and remove what does not.

> **Daily drill:**
> 1) Name the trigger.
> 2) Name the first body signal.
> 3) Run one reset action.
> 4) Log response quality.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Faith, God, and Big Questions After Trauma

Use this to track spiritual struggle after trauma and build a practical response you can repeat under load.

Where did this pattern show up this week?

List specific moments at work, at home, and in transition.

What did it cost you when it took over?

Name impact on body, mood, decisions, and relationships.

What two actions will you run for the next 7 days?

Choose actions small enough to use on hard days.

1. Trigger:
What activated the pattern?

2. Early body signal:
What did your body do first?

3. Reset action used:
What fast action lowered intensity?

4. Better next response:
What exact behavior will you use next time?

> Track this daily for one week, then tighten the plan around what actually worked.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Faith, God, and Big Questions After Trauma - Partner/Team Check-In

Use this page for one short practical check-in each week.

What do others notice first when this pattern is active?

Capture observable behavior, not labels.

What support helps most and least?

List what helps and what escalates the issue.

What agreement will you both practice this week?

One clear action from each side.

1. Signal phrase:

What phrase means pause and reset?

2. Time-to-return commitment:

When will re-engagement happen?

3. Repair step:

What specific repair happens after a rupture?

> Keep check-ins short, specific, and repeatable.

Closing

You've seen and carried more than most people will ever know.

Blow ups and shutdowns are not proof that you're broken or that your relationship is doomed.

They are signs that your nervous system has been running in survival mode for a long time.

The fact that you picked up this guide and read it matters.

You are choosing to be intentional about how you show up for the people who matter to you.

That choice is a lot more powerful than having flawless days.

About the Author

Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW

Founder, Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.